9 From Arab Nationalism to Islamic Fundamentalism

POINTS TO CONSIDER
From the late 1960s Arab nationalism lost its appeal and Islamic fundamentalism became a growing force in the Middle East. Al-Qaida emerged and later grew into a worldwide network of Islamic radicals. It achieved international notice in 2001 with its attacks on New York and Washington. This chapter examines:

- The rise of political Islam
- Al-Qaida and the globalisation of terror

Key dates

1967		Arabs defeated by Israel in Six-Day War
1979		Islamic Revolution in Iran Soviet invasion of Afghanistan
1990		Iraqi invasion of Kuwait
1990–1		US troops arrived in Saudi Arabia
2001	September	'9/11' attacks on New York and Washington
	October	US attack on Afghanistan
2003		US-led invasion of Iraq

1 | The Rise of Political Islam

Key question
What gave rise to the growth of political Islam?

When the Egyptian leader, Nasser, died in 1970, millions turned out for his funeral and he was mourned by many more millions throughout the Arab world. He had been a towering Arab leader, inspiring and exciting those who heard his speeches, whether at rallies or on the radio. He was the undisputed voice of Arab nationalism, the movement that united so much of the Arab world in its defiance of the West and Israel.

Key date
Arabs defeated by Israel in Six–Day War: 1967

However, Arab nationalism was already on the wane when Nasser died. The main reason was the crushing defeat which the Arab nations of Egypt, Syria and Jordan suffered in their war against Israel in 1967 (see pages 50–3). In that war, the Israelis proved that they were stronger than the three Arab states put together and they seized land from all of them. Arab nationalism was seen to have failed and lost its appeal as a unifying force in the wake of the Arabs' humiliation at the hands of Israel and its